The way forward

At the SCO Astana Summit in 2017, Prime Minister Modi reiterated full faith in the grouping and spoke about deepening India's association with the SCO.[24] The SCO could certainly become a new frontier for India and in the longer run create an environment for regional integration beneficial to India. Even so, SCO membership will not be able to smooth every conflicting interest India has with other member countries on various issues. I will here elaborate on opportunities and challenges India might face within the context of the SCO on four selected issues: combating international terrorism, India's relationship with Pakistan, China's Belt and Road Initiative, and the development of India's relations with the China–Russia–US great power triangle. Examining these issues, I will especially pay attention to converging and diverging views and interests between India and China.

Combating international terrorism

At the 2017 SCO Astana Summit, Prime Minister Modi expressed full faith in the SCO giving a new push to India's efforts combating terrorism.[25] In fact, rather than applying bilateral pressure, the SCO could be used as a neutral forum to discuss terrorism in a broader global and regional context. India could leverage the platform to obtain Beijing's cooperation on curbing Pakistan-sponsored terrorism. A key principle of the SCO Charter is "to jointly counteract terrorism, separatism and extremism in all their manifestations," which would make it difficult for China to unduly favour Pakistan or ignore the way it deals with these threats.